

LIFE LESSONS Suman More (with cap) and her friends with their solar dryer;(right) queue at the Sankalp 'milk ATM'in Urali Kanchan

Photographs by MANDAR DEODHAR

GEMS OF INDIA

RURAL SALVATION

BAIF's work among the rural masses since the late 1960s, especially in dairying and women's empowerment, has helped lift thousands out of poverty

By **DHAVAL S. KULKARNI**

Uruli Kanchan village, located some 30 km from Pune, first emerged on the map in 1946 when Mahatma Gandhi came to start a nature cure ashram here. He selected Manibhai Desai, still in his 20s, to manage it. Desai was later involved in a raft of rural initiatives, such as India's first cooperative lift irrigation scheme in the 1960s, even a sugar cooperative, before launching Bharatiya Agro Industries Foundation (BAIF) in 1967.

In 1970, BAIF pioneered the doorstep delivery of artificial insemination (AI) services for dairy farmers. "This helped boost milk production from the two litres per animal then.... If cattle breeds had not improved, milk production in India would have stagnated," says Bharat Kakade, the current president and managing trustee of the BAIF Development Research Foundation, while pointing to its role in India's 'White Revolution'. BAIF has